

laws demand that office signboards use the local language in addition to English. Using transliteration, the user interface looks more natural and friendly for a typical user

Technical acronyms

Technical acronyms such as OLE (Object Linking and Embedding), or RAM (Random Access Memory) are difficult to localise. When they are transliterated in Indian languages, they may be difficult to read—so for localising contexts where the user is supposed to have a bit of technical knowledge (like those who install operating systems) these acronyms can be left, as is. However, if they are to be presented to a lay user, then it is better that they are transliterated as individual characters or as a pronounceable word.

Culture-specific words

When we translate words like *India*, we prefer the more common Indic equivalent of *Bharat*, or its variations (variation 2, below) rather than a transliteration of India (variation 1, below). Similarly, when country names include the direction names, it is better to translate the direction name to the local language.

Example: From FUEL Telugu

English	Telugu (variation 1)	Telugu (variation 2)
India	ఇండియా	భారతదేశం
North America	నార్త్ అమెరికా	ఉత్తర అమెరికా

Keynames

Some keys have specific abbreviations like *Ctrl* and *Alt*, and most style guides suggest they be retained. I would suggest that as it is essential for everyone, transliterating the key name is more helpful.

Example: From FUEL Telugu

English	Telugu (variation 1)	Telugu (variation 2)
Both Ctrl keys together change layout.	రెండు కంట్రోల్ కీలు కలిపి నమూనాను మార్చును.	రెండు Ctrl కీలు కలిపి నమూనాను మార్చును

Foreign words ending with halanth

Meter - మీటర్, మీటరు
Road - రోడ్, రోడ్డు

While the first form is correct from a phonetic perspective, the words are appended with a 'u' sound, which makes it

more natural for Telugu speakers. However, if these are used in a context meant for professionals, the first form will be more appropriate.

Foreign words with multiple conjuncts for certain syllables

Software: సాఫ్ట్వేర్, సాఫ్ట్వేర్, సాఫ్ట్వేరు

The first form is closer to English pronunciation, but is difficult for the user to understand. It is better to use ZWNJ (second case) to simplify the conjunct formation and improve readability, and also make it end with the 'u' sound (third option) to make it natural for Telugu people.

Short-cut keys

Different software use different ways (preceding with '_, ' &', or '~') to highlight short-cut keys. In English, these keys flow in the usual text. For Indic languages, as there are several input methods and some keys for vowel *matras* need the support of dummy glyphs, it is not possible to use local language short-cut keys. So, usually, the English short-cut keys are put at the end of the string, in parentheses. But these are still difficult to use, as this requires changing the input method, so I suggest that we dispense with the short-cut keys, as mouse and touch-based interaction is becoming the norm. However, it is an accessibility aid, so may require a longer discussion.

Terminology

There is no unified terminology for most Indian language localisation needs. FUEL is a project by open source software teams, and Microsoft has its own terminology. It is essential for a specialised language centre to build a common terminology that can be used by all.

Quality assessment

Currently, it requires other team members to spot deviations from the guidelines. Some localisation tools are able to flag elements like extra spaces. It would be very useful to have localisation tools check for conformance to style guides. **END** 

For more information

- [1] FUEL style guides, <http://www.fuelproject.org/styleguide/index>
- [2] Microsoft style guides, <http://www.microsoft.com/Language/en-US/StyleGuides.aspx>

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